“What Do We Have to Do Now?” Questions Families Ask After a Parent Is Approved for Medicaid

Plain, general answers, and who can answer each one for Mom.

You're not the first family to open an approval letter and wonder whether that was the last form. These are the questions that come up most once a parent has Medicaid, answered in general terms.

None of the answers is about Mom in particular. Each state runs its own Medicaid program, so where a question depends on her state or her situation, the answer says so and says who to ask.

1 Mom was approved. Are we finished?

The application is finished, and that is worth a breath. Keeping up with Medicaid continues. Approval comes as a letter, and states are required to look again at eligibility through periodic renewals, so more mail from the agency is to be expected. What continues for the family is mostly a routine: open the letters, keep the dates, write down what changes. [1] [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you've read the approval letter and can't tell what it expects from the family. Ask the Medicaid agency or your Medicaid planner to go through it with you.

2 What do we have to do now that Medicaid has approved Mom?

It depends on the state and on Mom's case, and her own letters are where it is written down. In general, the federal renewal flyer comes down to three habits: keep your contact information with the state current, check your mail, and act on what a letter asks for. Each state decides how to run its own program, so the specifics for Mom come from her notices, the Medicaid agency and your Medicaid planner. [3] [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the approval letter names something the family is to keep doing, sending or paying, and nobody has explained it.

3 What is a renewal? Is a redetermination something different?

A renewal is the state reviewing a person's information to decide whether they still qualify. The sources below use redetermination for the same review. KFF explains that when a coverage period is ending the state sends a notice: if coverage was renewed automatically the notice gives the new coverage period, and if it wasn't, the notice includes instructions for completing the renewal. [3] [2] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know when Mom's next renewal is. That is a question for her state's Medicaid agency or your Medicaid planner; this page can't give a schedule.

4 What will the agency ask us for at a renewal?

It varies by state and by case, and the letter itself says what is needed. In general, states are meant to use the data they already have first, and to send forms and requests for documents when that isn't enough. The person then fills out the forms and provides income and asset information. Keep a copy of whatever you send, with the date. [5] [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** a renewal form or a request for documents arrives and you aren't sure what it wants. Bring it to your Medicaid planner, or ask the agency what it will accept.

5 What changes could affect eligibility?

That depends on the state and on Mom's situation, and deciding it isn't the family's job. In general, the nonprofit Justice in Aging notes that changes in a person's life, such as moving, retiring or a rise in income, can change their Medicaid eligibility. The Medicaid Planning Roadmap suggests keeping an eye on a short list: income, accounts and other assets, where Mom lives, her marital status where that applies, and her care setting. Write each change down with the date. [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** anything on that list has changed or is about to. Ask the Medicaid agency or your Medicaid planner what it means for Mom.

6 Do we have to tell Medicaid when something changes?

Ask, and expect the answer to depend on the change and on the state. States must have procedures for people on Medicaid to report changes in circumstances that may affect their eligibility, and they are required to handle a change using procedures meant to keep eligible people covered. Which changes, how to report them and by when come from Mom's own notices and from the agency. This page can't list them. [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you aren't sure whether something counts. Write down what happened and the date, and ask the agency or your Medicaid planner instead of settling it among yourselves.

7 Some money is coming to Mom that nobody planned on. What should we do?

Write down what it is, who it came from and the date, and ask before anything is done with it. An inheritance, a gift, the proceeds of a sale and an insurance payment all belong on the list. How any of them is treated is a question this page can't answer. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide for people managing a relative's money says that Medicaid is complicated, and to get legal advice and be very careful about decisions that may affect a person's eligibility. [6]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** money has arrived or is expected, or someone is thinking of making a gift, selling something or changing whose name is on an account. That goes to your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney first.

8 How do we make sure Mom doesn't lose her benefits?

Nobody can promise that, and this page won't. Whether Mom stays eligible is decided by her state, from her facts. What a family can do is keep its own part in order: make sure the agency can reach you, open what it sends, send what it asks for, write down what changes, and ask before acting on money or property. Justice in Aging gives advocates much the same advice for the people they help: keep contact information current with the state, and know which notices to look for. [3] [7]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you'd like someone to look over the whole picture with you: the notices, the renewals, the records and what has changed. That is what a periodic review with your Medicaid planner covers.

9 What if a letter says something we don't understand, or don't agree with?

Keep the letter and its envelope, and ask. If a state decides a person no longer qualifies, it says so in a letter, and the letter explains how to appeal. A person enrolled in Medicaid who disagrees with certain decisions has the right to ask for a fair hearing, also called an appeal, and the agency's written notice must say how to ask and how long there is to do it. If the notice isn't clear, the state Medicaid agency can explain the steps. [3] [8] [9]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** a letter says Mom's coverage or services are changing, being reduced or ending. Bring the letter itself to your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney, and point out the dates it gives.

10 Who does what from here?

The state Medicaid agency sends the notices and carries out the renewals, and it is the place to ask about the status of one; Medicaid.gov keeps a directory of every state's agency. In this roadmap, your Medicaid planner goes through the approval notice and the renewal requirements with the family and holds a periodic review. Legal questions go to an elder law attorney. The Family Caregiver Alliance lists a local Area Agency on Aging, a state senior legal hotline, or an attorney who specializes in elder law as ways to find legal help. [3] [10] [11]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you don't know which of them a question belongs to. Write it down, mark it “not sure,” and bring it to your Medicaid planner.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about Mom herself: what her state requires, which changes have to be reported or when, or whether anything affects her eligibility. Those answers come from her own notices, the Medicaid agency, your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You have plain answers to the general questions, and you know who can answer the rest for Mom. The planning interview is where the questions become about your family: it asks about your situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (Medicare.gov publication, CMS Product No. 11409, April 2026), Medicaid: Getting Started
2. Justice in Aging, Final Rule to Streamline Access to Medicaid
3. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS), Have Medicaid or CHIP? Get ready to renew your coverage
4. KFF, Do I have to renew Medicaid coverage every year?
5. National Center on Law and Elder Rights (Administration for Community Living), Responding to Common Medicaid Unwinding Issues for Dual Eligibles
6. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else's money: Help for agents under a power of attorney
7. Justice in Aging, Unwinding Medicaid Continuous Coverage Protections: Implications and Advocacy for Individuals Dually Eligible for Medicare and Medicaid
8. Medicaid.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Understanding Medicaid Fair Hearings
9. KFF, I learned that my Medicaid coverage has ended. What do I do now?
10. Medicaid.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Where Can People Get Help With Medicaid & CHIP?
11. Family Caregiver Alliance, What should I do to help get my family member's legal and financial affairs in order?